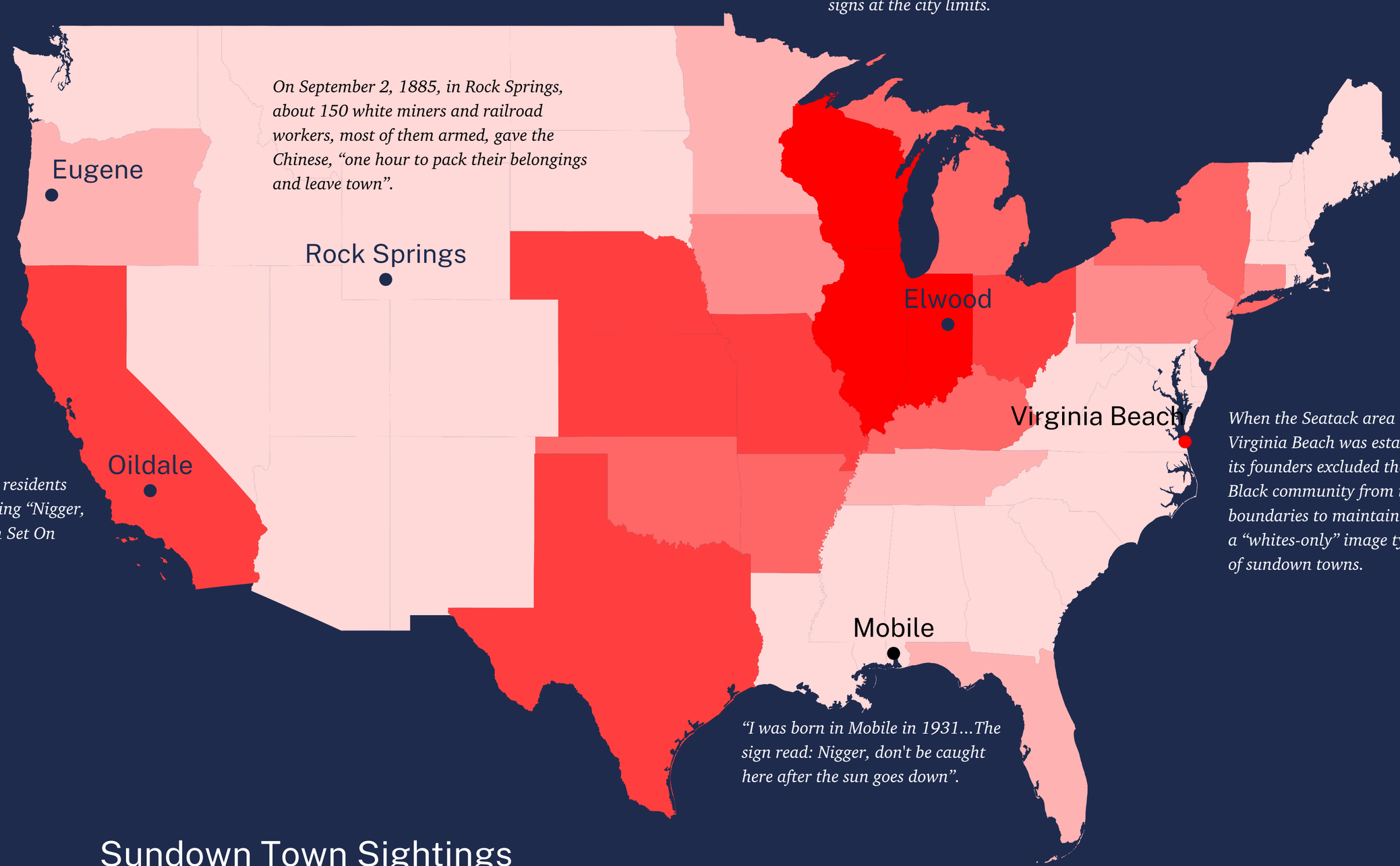
Sundown Towns Sightings by State

“Nigger, don't be caught here after the sun goes down”

“Sundown, sunset, or ‘gray’ towns emerged in the 1800s, enforcing racial exclusion through social boundaries, jurisdictional control, signage, violence, threats, and local community enforcement. Though often absent from official records, evidence from community memory, archives, and research suggests thousands of U.S. places practiced these forms of exclusion. Preserving and sharing these histories reveals how past spatial exclusion still shapes segregation, resources, and health care access today."

One Indiana resident remembers that Tipton, Elwood and Alexandria, all on State Road 28, each had the Sundown signs at the city limits.



A string of towns along what is now Interstate 5 in western Oregon — including Eugene, Umpqua, Grants Pass, Eagle Point, and others — primarily excluded African Americans.

On September 2, 1885, in Rock Springs, about 150 white miners and railroad workers, most of them armed, gave the Chinese, “one hour to pack their belongings and leave town”.

Several long time residents tell of a sign reading “Nigger, Don't Let The Sun Set On You in Oildale”.

When the Seatack area of Virginia Beach was established, its founders excluded the Black community from its boundaries to maintain a “whites-only” image typical of sundown towns.

“I was born in Mobile in 1931...The sign read: Nigger, don't be caught here after the sun goes down”.

Sundown Town Sightings

- 200-360
- 100-200
- 50-100
- 30-50
- 20-30
- 20 and under

Source: Loewen, J. (2005) Sundown towns: A hidden dimension of American racism. The New Press.

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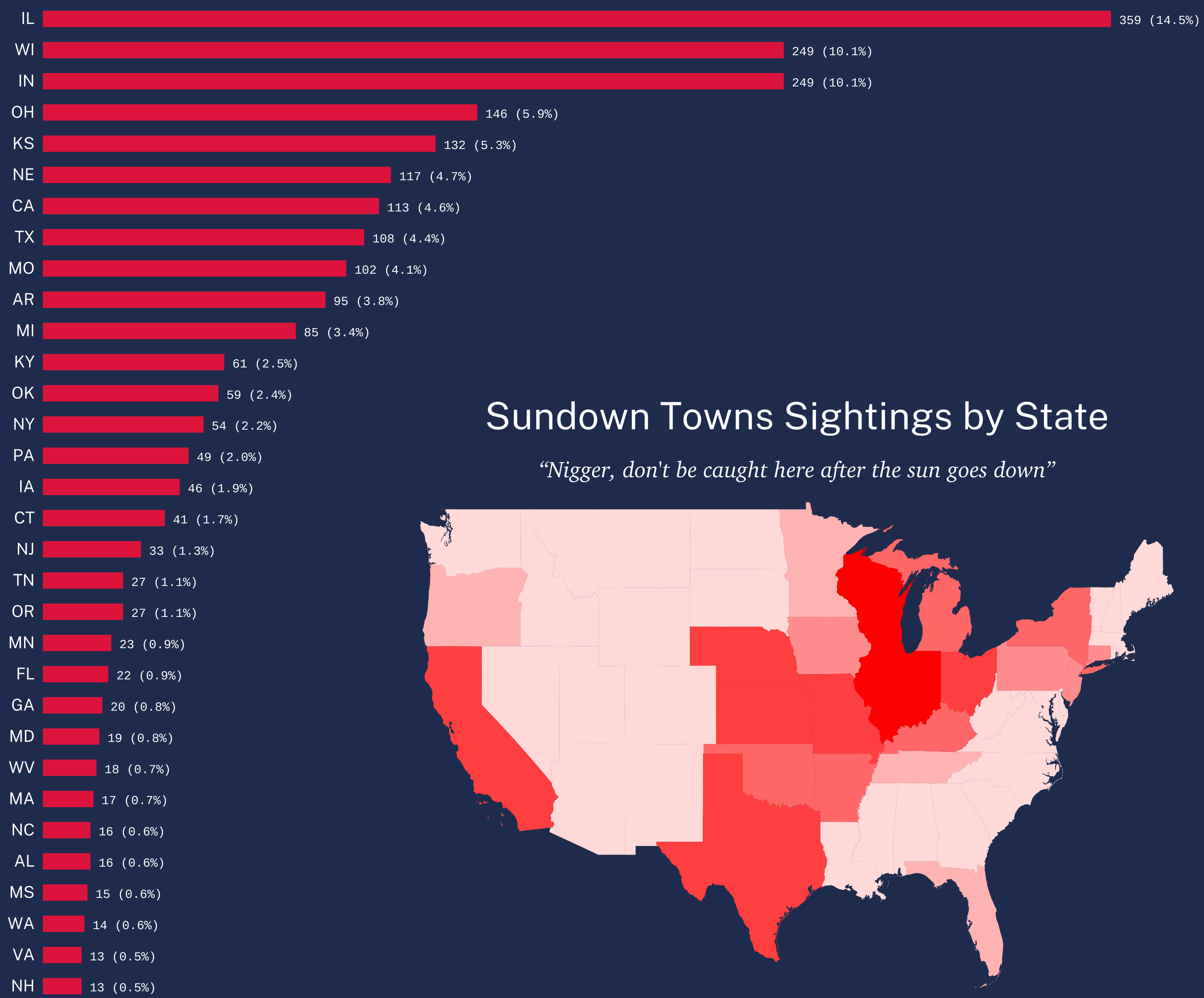

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Sundown towns spanned the U.S., with a strong concentration in the Midwest, exposing an often overlooked legacy of racism.

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